storage, and networks) as a commodity.

The cloud provider manages the underlying cloud infrastructure, so the consumer doesn't need to worry about physical resources like machines or networks. Companies moving to the cloud can get all the computing resources they need via a network (usually the internet) through a set of APIs that allows them to provision and scale resources as they need on an on-demand, self-service basis.

Elasticity is one of the main characteristics of this model: computing resources can be provisioned and released dynamically, depending on the demand.

> *Elasticity is the degree to which a system is able to adapt to workload changes by provisioning and de-provisioning resources in an autonomic manner, such that at each point in time the available resources match the current demand as closely as possible.*[4]

Traditional IT infrastructures weren't able to provide elasticity. Companies had to calculate the maximum computing capabilities needed and set up an infrastructure that would support that, even if most of it was only required sometimes. With the cloud computing model, the usage of computing resources is monitored, and consumers only pay for what they actually use.

There is no strict requirement about where the cloud infrastructure should be or who should manage it. There are several deployment models for delivering cloud services. The main ones are private cloud, public cloud, and hybrid cloud.